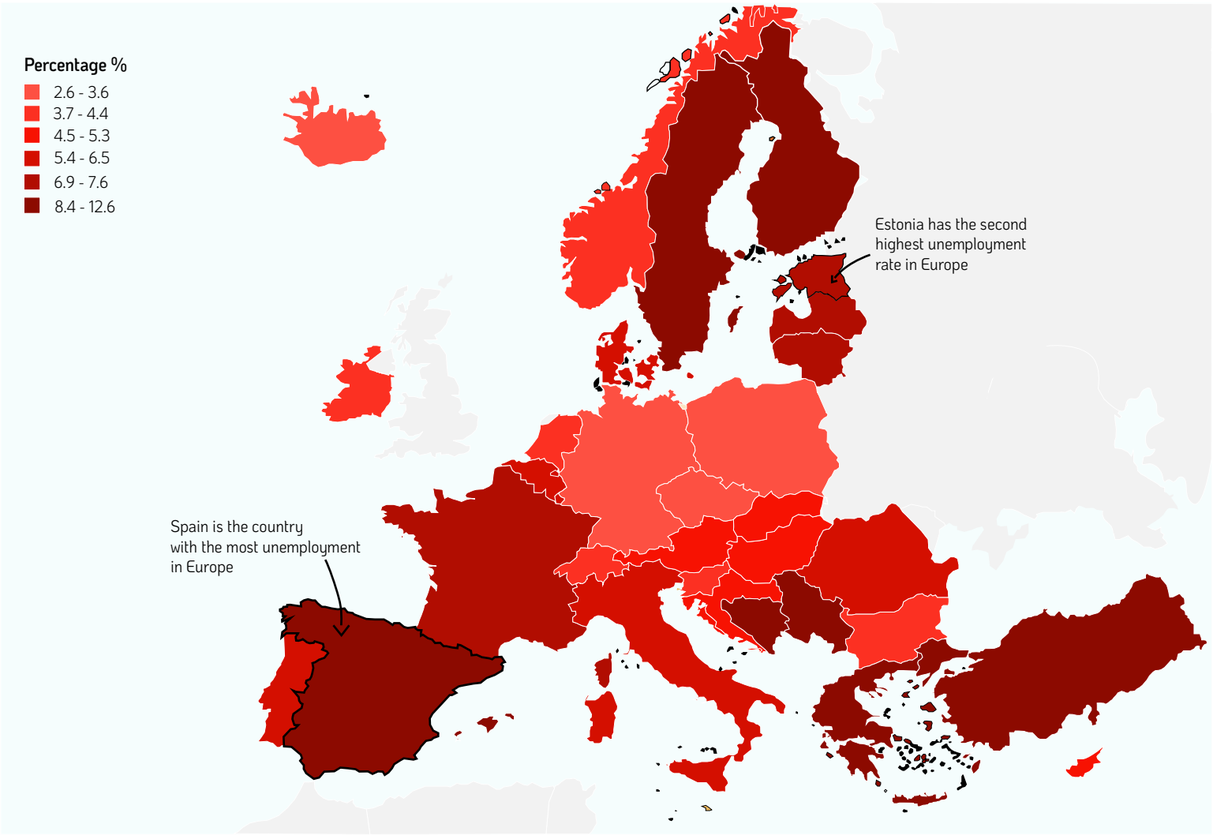
Unemployment in Europe, 2024

Unemployment rates vary widely across Europe, with southern and eastern countries facing the highest levels. The map highlights how economic conditions and job opportunities differ significantly across the continent



Youth Unemployment

The Silent Crisis: Youth Unemployment in the EU

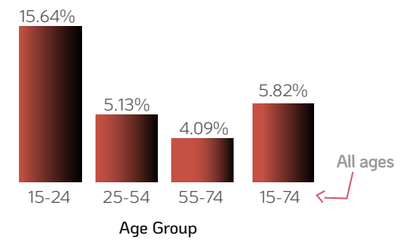
How do youth unemployment rates differ between Southern, Western, and Northern European countries?

Youth unemployment remains one of the European Union's most pressing yet overlooked issues. Although overall unemployment has declined since the pandemic, joblessness among young people continues to outpace that of older workers. In 2024, more than 15% of Europeans aged 15–24 were unemployed nearly three times the rate for adults. The problem is particularly severe in Southern Europe, where countries such as Spain and Greece report some of the highest youth unemployment levels in the region.

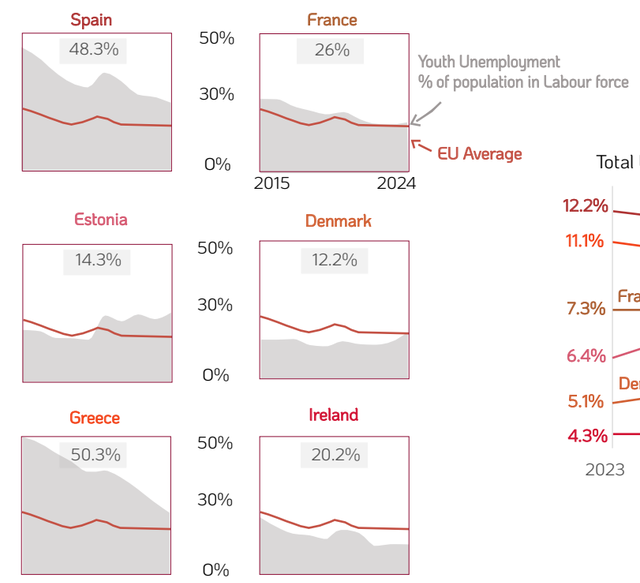
The contrast between Southern, Western, and Northern Europe exposes a deep regional divide. While nations like Denmark and Ireland maintain single-digit youth unemployment rates, Southern countries continue to struggle with slow job creation, economic instability, and limited access to training or entry-level opportunities. This persistent gap not only reflects unequal economic resilience across the EU but also raises concerns about the long-term social and economic integration of Europe's younger generation.

Despite gradual progress, tackling youth unemployment remains a central challenge for the EU's economic and social agenda. Initiatives such as vocational training, youth mobility programs, and targeted employment incentives aim to bridge the gap, yet progress is uneven. Unless stronger policies and investments create sustainable opportunities for young workers, Europe risks losing a generation to long-term unemployment and underemployment, a silent crisis with lasting consequences.

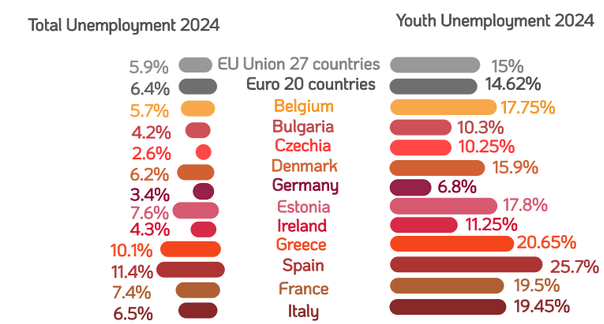
Average Unemployment by Age Group in EU (% of Labour Force) in 2024



This imbalance underscores the challenges young Europeans face in transitioning from education to employment particularly in countries where job markets remain rigid and opportunities for entry-level experience are limited.

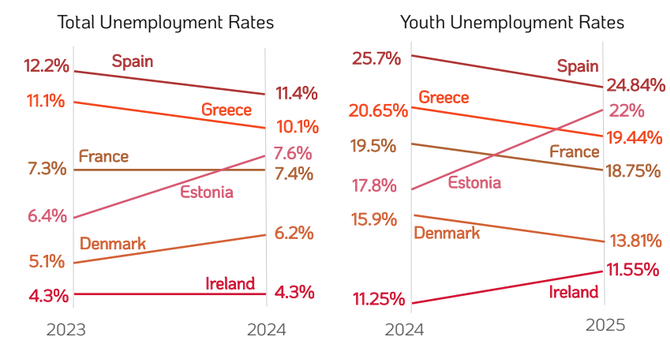


Unemploymnet Rates of 2024



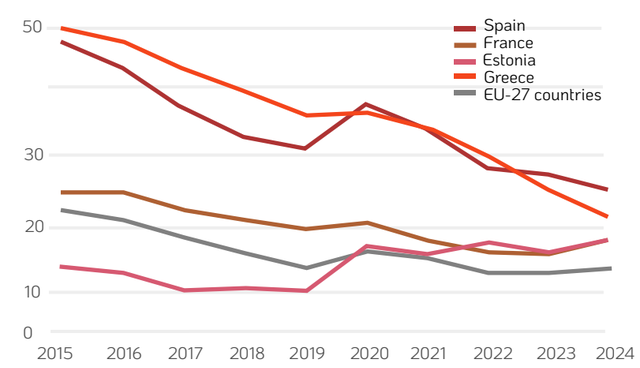
Countries in Southern Europe have higher percentages of total unemployment than the countries in Northern Europe. The two with the highest rates from each region are Spain and Estonia.

A Deep Regional Divide

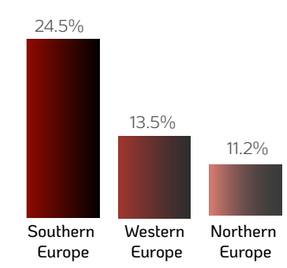


Northern and Western Europe see low youth unemployment while Southern countries struggle, highlighting unequal economic resilience and threatening youth mobility.

Evolution of Youth Unemployment 2015-2024



Regional Comparison (2024)



Southern Europe's youth continue to bear the brunt of economic stagnation, limited industrial diversification, and lower investment in vocational pathways. Meanwhile, Northern and Western Europe benefit from stronger economies, better education-to-work transitions, and higher labor market flexibility.

Source: Eurostat